

But Ser Piero didn't ignore his illegitimate child. He acknowledged that Leonardo was his son. However, he did not agree to marry Caterina (he was already planning to marry another young woman) or agree to take the baby into his home. So Leonardo lived with his mother for his first five years. She soon married Antonio Buti, a local furnace worker who produced lime for making pottery.

Caterina and Antonio quickly started their own family, giving Leonardo several half sisters.

WHAT IS ILLEGITIMATE?

This means not recognized as lawful. In medieval Italy (and in many other places), an illegitimate child did not have the same protection under the law as a child born to a married father and mother. Under the rules of the time, illegitimate children had fewer rights than children that were born as part of a legal family. For example, they could not go to college or become a doctor or a lawyer. As an illegitimate son, Leonardo's future career choices would have been limited, hemmed in on many sides.

